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Six months later, fire in mulch still burns

Wilmington frustrated as bids to extinguish fail

By Billy Baker

GLOBE STAFF

WILMINGTON — In September, the town of Wilmington was alerted to a fire in a mulch pile at an old farm property at 333 Andover St. When the Fire Department responded, what they found was no ordinary mulch pile. It was more like a mulch

mountain, 30-feet deep in places, as well as piles of logs. They extinguished the visible fire and believed it was contained, according to a statement from the fire chief.

Six months later, the fire is still going.

Infuriated neighbors in this town of 23,000 have raised repeated health concerns about having to breathe the smoke, including residents of a 55-plus senior development adjacent to the land. The property owners were plunged into a financial

bind. And the town was left with big expenses, as well as legal and ethical questions.

Mulch fires are notoriously difficult to fully extinguish, and fire continued to reappear at the site. In early fall, the Wilmington Fire Department brought in an excavator to turn over the entire pile, employed a drone with a thermal imaging camera to identify hot spots, and ultimately spent more than a month on scene trying to extinguish the fire. According to Fire Chief William F.

FIRE, Page A6

‘There are some days where it doesn’t feel safe to pull out of my driveway because I can’t see where I’m going.’

ERIC SALVADOR, *lives near Wilmington, fire*



KEN MCGAGH FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

On Wednesday, a Wilmington fire truck doused a mulch pile that has been smoldering since September.

A TURN TOWARD THE SUN

As temperatures fitfully begin rising around the Boston area, pedestrians and bicyclists have been passing along the North Bank Bridge at Paul Revere Park in Charlestown. **Weather, D5.**



FINN GOMEZ FOR THE BOSTON GLOBE

New Haven college flips script on international students

Administrators setting sights on Saudi campus as local enrollment plummets

By Diti Kohli

GLOBE STAFF

WEST HAVEN, Conn. — In February, University of New Haven president Jens Frederiksen traveled from Connecticut to attend the World Defense Show in Saudi Arabia. He was there to network with American companies and to tout his university’s upcoming campus in Riyadh.

Frederiksen described Saudi Ara-

bia as an “extraordinary frontier” for his West Haven, Conn.-based university. The mid-sized private college has educated Saudi students for three decades on campus and abroad. Now the kingdom has blessed the University of New Haven to be the first US school to open inside its borders this fall — the widening war with Iran notwithstanding.

“They want American degrees

the same way they are delivered in West Haven,” Frederiksen said to the Globe. “We are at the forefront of the line to answer the call.”

Those optimistic words belie financial challenges back home. Just a week before Frederiksen flew to Riyadh, the Saudi capital, he acknowledged in the Hartford Courant that enrollment had fallen by a third since 2024, from roughly 9,000 to 6,000 students, amid the Trump administration’s crackdown on foreign educational visas. In response, the school paused payments to employee retirement funds and

laid off around 20 student support staffers. Its master’s program in taxation is no longer enrolling new students. Deeper program cuts and faculty layoffs are coming next.

“We expect official announcements in the next few weeks,” Amy Baker, chair of the faculty senate, wrote in an email to the Globe.

The Riyadh campus is a key piece of New Haven’s turnaround plan. Frederiksen is betting that the branch location will help the college evade the worst impacts of the ongoing decline in international students

SAUDI ARABIA, Page A10

Two harrowing scenes stun residents of Danvers, Lynn

Murder suspect wandered through yards with knife

This story was reported by Globe staffers Lea Skene, Laura Crimaldi, Sean Cotter, Travis Andersen, John R. Ellement, and Claire Thornton. It was written by Skene.

SALEM — It was a chilling admission, one that led police to a grisly murder scene and left residents of two communities unable to fathom such random and unprovoked violence.

Found wandering a neighborhood in Lynn Thursday while holding a blood-covered knife, a senior at a North Shore Catholic high school allegedly told police he had “wanted to kill someone for a long time.” He then directed officers to a home in nearby Danvers, where they found a 68-year-old part-time nurse dead in her own bedroom, stabbed the night before.

Police said 18-year-old Anthony DeMayo of Lynn had driven around the North Shore late Wednesday night before pulling up in the suburban neighborhood in Danvers. He identified his target, seemingly at random: a single-story ranch house with a well-manicured lawn. Authorities say he climbed in the kitchen window, found a woman asleep in bed, and killed her.

And then DeMayo made his way back to Lynn, where after crashing his car in a resident’s yard, he wandered around the neighborhood in the middle

FATAL STABBING, Page A7

Neighborhood’s vibrancy tinged with emissions

Oil tank farms create air of uncertainty in Maine

By Sabrina Shankman

GLOBE STAFF

and Ryan Krugman

INSIDE CLIMATE NEWS

SOUTH PORTLAND, Maine — It’s one of Maine’s most desirable locations — home to a vibrant and diverse community, nearby beaches, and close proximity to Portland’s downtown. But for years, residents in South Portland have wondered: with 120 massive petroleum storage tanks dotting the shore and knitted into some neighborhoods, is the air safe to breathe?

Now the first answers are in, thanks to a year of emissions monitoring along the fence lines of the city’s tank farms. At two of those locations, the results showed levels of benzene — a known carcinogen — well above the state’s limit.

“We’re about 300 feet from those tanks,” said Ted Reiner, whose home is surrounded by three of the city’s tank farms. It’s where he and his wife raised their two daughters, now 38 and 28. Around Christmas, Reiner had surgery for bladder cancer. Now he’s undergoing immunotherapy, and he can’t help but wonder whether his environment is contributing to his health woes.

“You just don’t know what the cumulative effect is,” he said. “I think about it a lot.”

Reiner lives closest to the Citgo South Portland Terminal, in a part of the city known as Turner Island. The tanks there primarily hold gasoline,

AIR, Page A6

Connecting across country, generations

With a throwback booth, project links groups of diverging backgrounds

By Camilo Fonseca

GLOBE STAFF

and Hannah Goeke

GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

It’s no secret that Gen Z and baby boomers aren’t always on the same page. But a tech startup is betting that a new outdoor phone booth — yes, you read that right — may be the solution.

Installed outside a coffee shop near the Boston University campus, the phone booth is a direct line to a senior housing complex in Reno, Nev. But whether college students decide to pick up the receiver and “call a boomer” on the other side of the country — or answer a phone call from one — its creators say there’s more on the line than just a simple conversation.

The goal, according to Matter Neuroscience, the company that set up the phone connection, is simply to get younger and older people to talk to each other. In doing so, the company hopes not only to bridge the generational divide but also to provide a connection between two groups that studies show are the loneliest in the United States.



PAT GREENHOUSE/GLOBE STAFF

Using a phone near Boston University, Trishsha Sivalingam left a message for seniors in a Nevada housing complex.

BOOTH, Page A10



On breezy street

Saturday: Windy, some sun. High 46-51, low 30-35.

Sunday: Clouds, showers late. High 38-43, low 35-40.

Sunrise: 6:58. Sunset: 6:49.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.**

Obituaries, **C9.**

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A new portal will allow bystanders and families to report any potential misconduct by federal immigration agents in Massachusetts. B1.

US officials vowed to halt Iran’s attempt to shut down the Strait of Hormuz, a vital shipping route for oil tankers. A4.

Many in the Jewish community, citing the latest attack in Michigan, wondered whether synagogues could ever be secure. A2.

The Irish are still lifting a pint in camaraderie, but more often the contents are alcohol-free. A3.

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